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Frank Alkyer

Frank Alkyer, Publisher of DownBeat magazine, speaks about his role and responsibilities with America's foremost jazz publication.

Frank was interviewed in New Orleans, Louisiana on January 10, 2020 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive. Romy Britell participated briefly in the interview.

@ :48

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive in New Orleans at the 2020 Jazz Network conference and the place is crawling with jazz people, and I have one of them here, Frank Alkyer, who is the publisher of *DownBeat* and an author. Thank you for meeting with me.

FA: Thank you, it's a pleasure.

MR: I'm really nervous because you're an interviewer yourself, so —

FA: I'm nervous because I'm used to asking the questions.

MR: Yes that's right.

FA: And not answering them, so, yeah.

MR: I'm going to start out with an easy one. Which is more challenging, making a living as a jazz musician or making a living writing about jazz musicians?

FA: I will speak of other peoples' experiences because mine has been pretty good. I, you know, I grew up as a journalist, and my first job in jazz was as the editorial director for *DownBeat* magazine. I started there in 1989. So for me it's been a steady paycheck, good work, good work atmosphere, terrific. If you are a freelance jazz writer — very difficult, very difficult. As difficult or more difficult to make a living than it is as a jazz artist/jazz musician. Yeah.

MR: What attracts *DownBeat* to people who write reviews on books and records?

FA: Yeah. I think it's, I think there are writers who like their art along the road less traveled. It's like we are more interested in high art than pop art. And I think that they tend to be very thoughtful, very well read, very educated, very very — you know before they were jazz writers they were jazz record collectors. I don't know of anybody who wasn't a jazz record collector beforehand and they fell in love with the liner notes of, you know, Nat Hentoff and all the greats, you know, so those are the things that really, really, and I'm one of them. You know it's like there's no question I fell in love with jazz because I got to put the record on, carefully dust it off, slip the needle on, and read these liner notes from some of the greatest writers in the world, as this beautiful music is playing behind me so I can get a deeper understanding. So I think those are the things that really attract

MR: I remember that too and I'd go to the record store and you're flipping through and sometimes it was the cover, but then you flip that thing over and sometimes you even learned about the reviewers and you learned well I like this reviewer, if he likes this record I'll buy it.

FA: Right. That's exactly right, yeah. And that's just it. You know at *DownBeat* we're a little bit — we're geeky. We just are. It's like you look at our record reviews. There's a star rating; there's a review; and at the end of the review there's a track listing with, there's a tie; the album number, it's like the code for the album in the catalogue; all the songs; how long this is, it's 46 minutes, is it 53 minutes, whatever it is; a listing of all the players that are in that band. And that's what makes our reviews different from other people. There's no other magazine that goes to that length to really put the details out there. Because if you listen to a record by Miles Davis, Thelonious Monk, you also wanted to know, who's the bass player? Who's the drummer? And that goes for the people that are playing today as well.

MR: Have you started down the path of reviewing musical releases that are not a physical product?

FA: Yes.

MR: Oh you have.

FA: Yeah. I don't think that there's any way around that. It's like that has changed. We were talking the other day about, because now there's a trend that's coming up that people are not releasing full albums, they're releasing an EP, an extended play record of maybe four songs, or even singles. And how is *DownBeat* going to handle that? And I look at it and I go, I think we'll handle it exactly how we did back when we first started doing reviews in the era of the 78, when there were just two sides. So you would review the two sides of that record and that was it. There was no album. It was just a 78 and it would have two songs, one on each side, and I go we're just going full circle.

MR: So the hopeful musician, they pay for the recording themselves, they make their own CDs and they put it in an envelope and they send it to *DownBeat*. Is that fruitless?

FA: No it's not. It's not fruitless. But we get about 50,000 records a year. We, in the magazine itself maybe we review five to six hundred. So you know maybe ten to fifteen percent of the records that we get in. But even in sending it to us a lot of people just email it to us. We get links now. We get them digitally, and a lot of times we're not even getting the physical product. We still do. Those things come in, and you know I've got bins in my office and the reviews editor has three times as many bins in his office. But a lot of times we get them in but what has to happen is the artist, you've got to follow up. If you send it out into the ether, you need to have somebody that's going to follow up and call us and

pieces of music that come into the office every year. And during certain periods it's much busier than others. So you've got to make a phone call and try to get that to the top of the list for us to give it a listen to see if we're going to review it or not.

MR: I'm not sure how to ask this but I'll try. If you put on, say it's an actual CD and it's really bad, but it's by a well known artist, do you think you would review it?

FA: Yes. We feel a responsibility to review it, yeah. If we put on — and when I say — when you say really bad I want to point out that in jazz everybody can play and then it's what you choose to play. So everybody can play but was it well rehearsed, is it well produced, are the songs compelling? Is the composition — the musicianship is pretty much always good. Good to great. Because they're just that good. So but yeah, if there's a well known artist and they put out something that the reviewer doesn't think is good and gives it one star or a half star or two stars, yeah, we feel compelled to run it. If it's a brand new artist and we put it out and we think it's going to harm them more than help them because nobody knows who they are anyway, we will often times pull that review.

MR: Okay.

FA: I just think that's fair. I think it's fair to the artist, and we let the artist know we pulled the review, it got a one star review. Sometimes we'll even, if we feel, you know, there are times that I love things and other people don't. And I can't figure out why. So we may take it and give it to another reviewer and see what they think of it. And then from there, at that point we'll say we're not going to hurt this person's career at this point. If they become famous then we have to really review it.

MR: I don't know why, you just said something that reminded me, this was before your tenure, I think it was the late 70s. I remember a review by a release by Gap Mangione. And I sort of knew Gap, not at the time, but I knew Chuck. But it was Gap's record. And apparently on the liner notes the writer was celebrating the chemistry of the trio. So the reviewer wrote: "If this is chemistry then women are wearing concrete underwear." And I was like, "Did I just read that?" And I'm not sure I got the exact — but that was the thrust of it. And he was really, really nasty on this review. And boy, I guess I pictured Gap reading that. So my follow up question is do you or does someone have like veto power, like if somebody writes that kind of thing that's so —

FA: There are times where an editor will say, or I'll say if it comes up to me, I end up being the ombudsman for the company. You know people can't decide what to do with things or there's an argument whether we should do this or do that, the editors will come to me with that kind of problem and then we'll work out a solution. But yeah, if we think the writer is being unfair, and there are times where it slips through because it doesn't seem that way to us, and then later on I'll go yeah, right, if the artist comes — you know

then I'll say yeah you're absolutely right. Arturo Sandoval one time, we did a double review of two records of his. One got two stars, one got four stars. And I went to see Arturo live. And he goes, "Frank, what are you doing?" I go, "What's the problem?" He goes, "Those reviews were awful." I go, "Arturo what are you talking about?" He goes, "The four star review, all you talked about were the negatives in the review. In the two star review you only talked about the song that he liked." And I go, "Really?" And I went back and I read it and I wrote him an apology letter. I said, "You are absolutely a hundred percent right." And I sat down with the editorial staff and I go, "This is an example of how we can go wrong. Just look at this. We're journalists. We have to like figure out — we always have to like say what are we doing wrong. What's wrong with this piece that we're writing, and try to, you know, it's kind of a weird way to live, but we're always looking for what's wrong and correct the spelling, correct this, correct the grammar, correct the thought process. Every word was spelled right. The sentences were complete. They were compelling. But the thought process was wrong. Why not tell you what you like about a good album, and why one misses maybe. And that's all he was complaining about, and he was a hundred percent right.

MR: Oh. A learning process all the time.

FA: All the time.

MR: Yeah. 1939 the magazine was founded?

FA: 1934.

MR: 1934. Do you think you have a similar mission statement now?

FA: [laughs]

MR: I didn't know I made a joke.

FA: Well in 1934 there was no mission statement believe you me. You know the first issue I think was eight pages long and it was basically a listing of all the bands and where they were playing and who was in the bands, because the guy who started the magazine sold life insurance policies to the — he was also a saxophone player on the side — but he sold life insurance. And he wanted to keep track of his clients. So *DownBeat* started as a little newsletter for this guy who sold life insurance. So there was not much of a mission statement other than hey, how do I keep track of my clients in 1934. That changed pretty quickly in 1935 when this guy named Benny Goodman, this kid became an overnight sensation across the country. And Benny Goodman is from Chicago, *DownBeat* was a hometown magazine, we had the inside story, all boats were rising with Benny Goodman. And that became *DownBeat*'s reason to be, covering Benny Goodman, covering everything he's doing in those early days. Really, really, really. It was like *Rolling Stone* covering the Beatles in the 1960s. It was that kind of an element that thrust it forward. So

journalists, they were musicians mostly. They were cantankerous, they were, you know it was, there was some funny stuff that would go on. And I wish that we could do some of that. And sometimes we try to get an element of it, but we just can't be quite that freewheeling when you're 85 years old and you've been around for all this time. We have a little bit more weight and gravitas that we need to present in the magazine, so —

MR: Plus those big bands provided such drama. I have some from the mid-40s and first of all the look of them is just so wonderful. But these titles, like: "Dorsey Hires New Canary." And the language. And the orks, they called them orks for orchestra.

FA: Orks, yeah, O-R-K.

MR: And some guy left some band for some other band it was like —

FA: Yeah. It was a [gestures] connect the dots, connect the dots. Yeah. It was a much different thing. It was really, well you've got to think, they, it was very newsy. And James C. Petrillo, you know, the union boss in Chicago, we were covering how Petrillo was trying to make musicians do things they shouldn't be doing, and James C. Petrillo was a man who had a huge ego. The C stood for Caesar. His middle name was Caesar. And he acted like a "Caesar" in those days. So yeah, you had all these like stories. It was really — they were trying to figure out what they were. It probably wasn't until the later 1940s and into the 1950s that *DownBeat* became kind of like, that its mission started to become present. And they said okay, now we've been around for a while, here are the things we should do, and thoughtful journalism and really, really good writers and that kind of thing. In those early days it was pretty freewheeling.

MR: Do you think, well you probably know this — what's your target audience?

FA: Yeah. People always ask me for demographics, and I go I can't give you demographics. I can but *DownBeat* is a psychographic. We use psychographics. People who are educated or will be educated, love music, generally play music or have played music or will play music, want the better things in life, love the arts, and they could be 13, they could be 89. And that's who it is. Because that 13-year-old is going to grow up to be that person over there and they may be a musician or they may be a lawyer or a doctor or — we're a magazine for readers. And we become for readers at a very young age. So I always look at it like our target audience is, it's like where do you go in this world to get your audience? And we always look at it as we really focus on musicians first and then fans of jazz want to feel like they're backstage with the musicians. So they come next. So basically the people that come to festivals and things like that. And then anybody else that wants to come along for the ride is good. But you know it's like, for example, we give out 15,000 copies a month during the school year to junior high, high school and college students. Free. We just tell — steal this magazine. We give it to their band

and sign up for a free digital subscription for as long as you're in school, all you have to do is tell us what year you are in school, where you are at, what your instrument is, what you're doubling on, and you know, that's it. Four quick questions and you get a free digital subscription for as long as you're in school. Because that's our next generation.

MR: You're setting up for the future.

FA: Yeah. It's like, you know, I learned from going to church on Sundays that to get people into the Kingdom of Jazz you reach them when they're children.

MR: Okay. Are you familiar with a publication called the *Mississippi Rag*?

FA: Yeah of course.

MR: Okay. So the fellow that bought it is actually an acquaintance of mine in Utica, New York. He bought it and he changed the name to *The Syncopated Times*.

FA: Right.

MR: So the reason I brought this up, they have this niche within a niche and they are very faithful and sometimes semi-obnoxious about what this music is — which leads me to ask do you have some kind of way of keeping track of what kind of jazz you've written about in the last ten issues and what do you project for the next ten? Because there's so many styles out there and some could be forgotten.

FA: I might get the date wrong on this, but *DownBeat* ran a contest to re-name jazz because jazz had become — it came to mean too many things to too many people. And we offered a thousand dollars for the winner. We wrote an editorial, put it out there and had this contest. That was in 1939 I believe. And the winning entry? Was crewcut.

MR: Go figure.

FA: What the heck was that? Well okay let's just like throw another 70 or 80 years of jazz history on top of that and you go, we can't, no, we're just going to go — luckily we're still a family-owned publication. The Maher family, Kevin Maher owns it, his father owned it before him, his grandfather owned it before him. And so, and they're not jazz people. They're business people. And they've stayed — but they've always stayed out of the way and they've always had an appreciation for good editorial, that they thought they had a philosophy that good editorial will mean good ad sales because that means we're going to have a bigger audience that's going to want to read. So that, into this is what I was hired into and man oh man, when I talk to people at other publications and you know, going through hard times, I think that we still succeed for a few reasons. Number one jazz education, number two we're still allowed to apply our craft and really look at it as a craft and not just content. You know everybody uses the word content. We don't use that in our office. What we do is we craft fine articles and we craft fine design. And we work hard. This is what we — for me it's like I want to put forth to my staff and to the

world that this is a team of craftsmen. And this is what we do. So I feel like I'm going astray on the question. Reel me back in.

MR: Well a person might, "Dear *DownBeat* editor: It's been six months since you said anything about trad jazz." Do you try to keep this in mind? We haven't done anything, we haven't focused on any Latin musicians in the last two months.

FA: Yeah we do. Well we really try to keep in mind, okay, in our feature and whatever, do we have drummers? Do we have drummers as leaders and saxophonists and trumpeters? We don't want to have four saxophonists every month for the next ten months. We don't want to have all smooth jazz all the time. We don't want to have all avante garde all the time. We have to understand. But we also have to understand that we're entertaining an audience of 75,000 readers a month in that magazine. 75,000 readers a month — you can't — I can't put somebody on the cover of the magazine who can't sell out a 200 seat room. So you've got to like think about that. So there's a sales aspect to it, but it's also an art aspect. So there's a commerce side to what we do, sure. We need to entertain this audience. And sometimes we'll take a chance and we'll try to make it make sense. It's like hey, here's somebody over here, that they appeal to this audience there but they're important to jazz and here's why. And they'll come along — and if you do it the right way they'll come along for the ride for everything. So yeah. But we do think about it from instrumentation, and listen, in this era we have worked extremely hard to make sure that women instrumentalists especially are represented in the pages of *DownBeat* every month. Because there are more and more and more women who are playing this music at a very high level and deserve our attention, and we need to, we just — jazz needs to grow up in that sense. It needs to like realize that hey, this is not a boys' club and it's not going to be a boys' club twenty years from now our industry is going to look much, much different, and our art form is going to look much, much different from the standpoint of, you know race, color, sex, than it does now. And we want to help lead that and now be lagging behind to be pulled along.

MR: Do you also have a prediction about what the music might sound like?

FA: I think that you will get much more — there'll be — it'll sound like many things. You will have a group of people who are just as you said trad jazz, that's a bebop focus, you're going to have an element of people who are really into technology, so I think we'll see a lot more electronic improvised music that people will say is not jazz. Is it? Is it not? Leave that up for the debate. I think you'll see more of that. But one of the most freeing things for jazz artists about the streaming era is, they're not really making money on CDs so they can make their statement any way they want. They don't have a bunch of record companies that are telling them how to make the records, so they're making records they

to be known as an artist." And so we have to go along with that too. I think you're going to see a lot more crossover kind of thing with like a Robert Glasper, along those lines. And people who are bringing in the elements of hip hop or soul or country or whatever it might be. You're just going to see that expand exponentially.

MR: Have you heard the line, "writing about music is like dancing about architecture"? And I assume you've written your own record reviews?

FA: Oh yeah.

MR: A few thousand maybe. Do you sometimes search for that elusive adjective describing —

FA: How do I describe this? Yeah. When all I want to say is, "This is bad ass." And I have. But it's like you know as a writer there are like any critic there are little isms in your writing, things that you do all the time. There are little phrases that you use. And I slap my wrist, try to break myself of that, try to move in, think of a different way to describe it. Can you really describe what they're doing? Well one of the ways I think is just to work to understand music and music theory better, and use terms, musical terms, rather than kind of esoteric — this is how it makes me feel — but this is what they're doing. So not that I'm — I'm not as good as others but that's what I try to do — understand what they're doing. Think about what they're doing. You know, and try not to describe it in terms of like how it makes me feel, but what they're doing and why it seems kind of cool.

MR: Okay.

FA: How the horns play against — you know are playing in unison or against, in counterpoint, or that it really gives it this effect of anger, grace, love, you know, the reasons behind it. So it's not just the words that you're using but it's also trying to give a little depth into what they're doing to make that feeling happen.

MR: I think it might have been here, I saw one of the many books, sort of like how to listen to jazz. Or perhaps it was an article. Do you ever run anything like you might find this helpful when listening to jazz, like an article like that.

FA: I don't think so. I like that idea though. I may steal it.

MR: I need a byline.

FA: Very good.

MR: Because over the years I've done some workshops and stuff, and I find that there's variations of this comment: "I like jazz until the melody is done with and then I don't know what they're doing, they're just playing anything they want" when in fact that's not really true. But at any rate —

FA: And that's when it gets interesting for those of us that love it.

MR: Yes.

FA: It's like that concept of what's next.

FA: Yeah, I did. But I always wanted him — his time at *DownBeat* I don't think ended well back in the 50s, which is a recurring theme. I like to think it hasn't happened as often under my tenure there. But there were turf wars, there were people, but Nat Hentoff, I started reading Nat Hentoff not necessarily in *DownBeat* but when I lived in New York and the *Village Voice* when he was covering the Supreme Court. And I loved his writing. You know the *Village Voice* was my paper in New York City. That was the thing that I ran to every Thursday and bought for a buck and read it cover to cover because it was covering the things that I wanted to see. And Nat Hentoff was one of them. And he was just heroic to me. And he was one of those guys too, it's like okay after I learned about it, this was like when I was 22, 21, 23 maybe, when I got to New York. So I went back and started looking up Nat Hentoff things, go to the library and look up old *DownBeat*s. It's like I heard — and read it — and still to this day his writing going back to your point about writing about music, what he did was ingenious and right, that he would let the artist speak. So as a result of people like Bill Gottlieb and Nat Hentoff and Dan Morgenstern that the artists' voice is front and center in those pieces, most of those pieces. Instead of having a critic that would just wax eloquently for 2000 words about an artist and never quote them. That doesn't have a lot of lasting value. It's interesting. But those direct interviews with those artists capturing what they are thinking at the time are gold. They're just so inspiring. But you were asking about Nat. Sorry.

MR: Yeah, no. We got to know him a little bit. I did an interview with him and it was a challenge. Not 'cause he was — he was very nice. But he was Nat Hentoff. And I felt like everything I'm asking him I hope is not like silly.

FA: Yeah, yeah, yeah. He was a good guy. But I think he was kind of like, you know, but we worked on a couple of projects. It's like he would call up, "Hey Frank I'm putting together a book can I get" — because we owned the rights to those articles. I said of course. And for those people we would just say yeah, those are your articles, you have the right to do that. There's no charge for that. So we would work together on things like that. And when there was an anniversary issue we had us write some pieces for us. Yeah, yeah. And it was great. I was never happier than when a Nat Hentoff piece would run in *DownBeat* magazine.

MR: I don't know if you'd share this with me but what's the biggest, most significant disaster you've had in your tenure at *DownBeat*, with some kind of article or a mistake.

FA: Wow. There have been a few. The biggest disaster.

MR: You know this is interesting, I rarely ask this question with musicians and I tried it a bunch of times, and the question was, "What's the worst gig you ever played." And I don't know if anybody's ever actually answered it. And if at all it usually isn't something

FA: Right, right, right. Well for me there are things that didn't happen. Things that we tried to do, all right — this is just, to this day, oh, things that didn't happen. I loved Tito Puente. I got to spend time with him, got to know him, I loved his music before that, I loved it after that, I loved Tito Puente. And the timing of his death was such that it would have been great stress on the staff to put him on the cover, and putting him on the next cover would have been too far away. So it was just — and I wish we'd have ripped up the issue and done it. We should have put Tito on the cover of the magazine when he passed away. A missed opportunity. There was another one where B.B. King and Les Paul are in New York City. B.B. is going to play a gig in New York City, Les is in New York City. We wanted to get B.B. King and Les Paul together to do a conversation because they both had great respect for each other. I thought this was a brilliant idea. B.B. wanted Les to go five blocks south to his hotel to do the interview. Les wanted B.B. to go five blocks north to Iridium to do the interview. We offered a limo either way, it didn't matter, either way we were willing to do it. The negotiations lasted about two weeks. We could not get either one of them to budge from their position and had to abandon this article, and it's just like ahhh. I would have loved to have that. These two giants of their respective genres of the art form together to talk about it. So that is a missed opportunity. I don't think, the disasters are like not really disasters, just people not doing their job so we've got to be there until two o'clock in the morning or things like that. You know, it's the stuff that goes on behind the curtain that we don't want you to see. I can't remember like doing something, we've made mistakes, we've had to correct things in the magazine, but I can't remember something that I'd go yeah we really screwed things up there. Most of it was just something happened on the back end and we had to scramble or just work inordinate hours to get the product out and make sure it was still good.

MR: You were mentioning about the cover with Tito Puente. How far ahead — when does your magazine have to be done?

FA: Okay, well we look at it and we start the idea and it's a three month process. Every magazine. So we always have like three magazines at all times, you've got one foot in this, another foot there, and your third foot is in the present. So yeah, so it's a three month process. But from start to finish of like, the day that the ads close there's one month where we literally okay, get the stuff in, get it edited, get it to design, get it out the door, get it uploaded to the printer. So that's a four week process. But the whole thing of assigning interviews, arranging the interviews, getting the interviews, getting it back in, getting the records in, reviewing the records, taking it out, from the time that the copy literally comes in to the time it's clean polished, designed, and put to bed is a four week process. The whole process, three months.

FA: Put it to bed?

MR: Yeah.

FA: There's different levels of it. I do the final approval on everything. From the design and editorial side Bobby Reed does the final approval. So basically the designer, the editor, they do their final approval on their side of the job. The job comes to me and then I do my final approval on that. So I'm approving their work in essence.

MR: Okay. Do you have an opinion on the state of jazz?

FA: Yeah. Lots of them.

MR: Well let me hear them.

FA: I think jazz, for the people that think jazz is dead, you know, good luck. No. I think jazz is healthier than it's been maybe in the history of jazz. I think it probably is, as an entire ecosystem. But within that there are problems, and the streaming issue is a problem. Record companies who have millions and millions and millions of titles can now make a living off of streaming. Because they get one nth of a percent for every play, so they don't care which title you play, they've got millions of them. But if they get one nth of one percent on that title that you played then they can make a living, and they're finally seeing a revenue stream coming out of that. The artists could never produce enough quote unquote content to maximize that. So what is there from that side of the business, what is their gain? A lot of artists are questioning, why should I make CDs? Why should I make albums? Why am I doing this, because I'm not going to make money from it. Well you know, it's a calling card. It gives people a reason to book you for a festival or for a tour or for this or for that. You have to do these things. But that's so wrong minded for us because we think an artist makes a record because that's what you do and you're making a statement. To me it's like you're making that record because you want to make great art. And that's something that a lot of people are debating. Because you don't have the budgets, the producers, the big studio money behind you and things to make a jazz record, which most of the record companies back in the day knew would not make money, but it was something they thought was the right thing to do. You know. So yes, I think there's a health to it, but even the record companies that are there, you look at them, they're generally jazz angels who are doing this because they love jazz, not because they're out to make money. You know Mack Avenue Records, Gretchen Valade, Mack Avenue, she's the heiress to the Carhartt fortune, the working clothes gear. And she loves jazz. So she started a record label and has some of the finest artists in the world on that record label. She went to the Detroit Jazz Festival when it was about to go under because of lack of funding, and she endowed it for fifteen million dollars, and then she put a management team in place to make sure that it was running smoothly and efficiently and

Detroit. She gave another eight million, I think it might be up to ten or twelve million dollars now, to Wayne State University to build a jazz performance facility, it's right outside of Detroit. But that's a jazz angel.

MR: I guess. That's a jazz saint too.

FA: Yeah. And there are a few of those, there are a few of those out there. So you've got like those kinds of things, yeah. But artists are finding different ways to make — they're entrepreneurial. Jazz musicians are entrepreneurial and they're finding ways to make that living and make their music the way that they want to make it.

MR: Okay. Like attending this event we're at now.

FA: Attending this event. Yeah. It used to be the old saying, you know, "Those who can't play teach." Well that's so very wrong because today you've got some of the finest jazz musicians in the world taking posts at universities large and small. And they're doing it because hey, it's a steady paycheck, it's a pool of young artists that they can use on their projects, it's health insurance, it's all the things that they want plus most of these universities are giving them the space to go out and tour when they need to tour and record, because that again, in turn, draws students to those programs. So that's been a real, really interesting development in jazz that it's a different crop of people that are taking over some of these jazz programs out there. A lot of them.

MR: Do you pay much attention to your competitive magazines?

FA: I used to when I was younger. And then, and I think it was probably around the 2008, 9, when the big recession hit and you know both of my major U.S. competitors, we can say the names, *JazzTimes* and *JazzIz*, they're friends of mine. *JazzIz* went dark and was sold and came back out. But they had some financial issues and they could no longer do it. *Jazz Is* magazine, the Fagans, the husband and wife, great people individually, they were great together too. But they got divorced and they went dark because there was a divorce and who was going to take over this asset. So when that happened I started going you know what? I can't control what other people do. We can only control what *DownBeat* does. Let's just focus on *DownBeat* and what we do. But I do want them to be healthy. I will say I do look at them every month, and if they're thin and they're not looking healthy, or in *JazzIz*'s case it comes out quarterly now, that's not good for us. We need good competition. It's like otherwise we'll get lazy.

MR: Yeah.

FA: It's human nature. So it's one of these things where I appreciate my competition. I want them to be sharp. I want them to make me better.

MR: Okay. After describing how many CDs you get every year, either physical or on-line, I was going to ask what do you listen to at home, but maybe you don't want to listen to

FA: Yeah, because I listen in the office a lot. But at home I'll listen to — sometimes I'll listen to jazz; sometimes I'll listen to, you know, rock; sometimes I'll listen to classical; I love country. I love music. I love music. Jazz is what I do for the living and it's informed by everything else that I hear. So I'm somebody who you'll, even in the office people go, "What are you doing in there?" Because I'll just have a playlist and they'll go, "What is that?" And you know it's one hit of bebop, one hit of avante garde, a Johnny Cash record over here, Nat King Cole over there, the newest big band out of Sweden out that way. It's like ahhh, it's one big happy family in my mind, so, yeah.

MR: If there's one person, a musician, that you could have interviewed but was gone before, who would you have liked to have been able to sit with? That's a hard question.

FA: No, there's a lot of them. You know who I wouldn't? Miles Davis.

MR: Well that's interesting because of the writing and the editing you've done with the material.

FA: I would have been scared to death. I would have been frightened to death. Frightened to death. I don't get intimidated often. He would have intimidated the living you-know-what out of me. But —

MR: Even his voice, man. Like, "How could you say that, Frank?"

FA: Yeah. But if I could sit down a day with Thelonious, if I could spend a day with Thelonious Monk I would have loved to spend a day with Thelonious Monk. If I could spend a day with Ellington, oh my gosh would that be a great day in life. You know Charles Mingus. If I could sit down with Charles. When I read *Beneath the Underdog* when it first came out, I just go, I wish I could have — because I just thought it was a brilliant book and the way that he did it in the third person. It was, I wish I could have spent time because that's a brilliant mind there. Yeah. Those are a few. Those are a few. Let's see, I'm trying to think if there is anyone else that I haven't spoken with. No, that covers a pretty good swath. Louis Armstrong. Oh, can't not leave that out. I would have loved to sit down and spend time with Louis Armstrong. Yeah.

MR: Cannonball Adderley was my guy. He still is my guy as far a just the whole package.

FA: Oh yeah. That would be a great one too.

MR: We had a great interview with Nat, but Cannon, you know, he passed in '74 or something. Did you ever ask a question during an interview that you suspected might get you a really nasty answer but you like fell on your sword just to see if you could get something? I don't know if I've ever done that — it takes some —

FA: I'm a nice guy. No.

MR: Yeah okay. Well we'll get along fine then.

FA: Well you know I think I try to ask questions in a way that's — you know I'm a farm kid

try to like maybe prime it with a couple of questions and then ask it in a way that will let us maybe get — you know it's not — I don't ask it in New York style, I ask it in Midwestern style, where it's going to take ten questions to get to the answer. We're going to ease on down into that alley.

MR: Do you have anything?

RB: Yes I do. I'm thinking of people who might be watching this interview and want to know how they can get their stuff noticed by you, and does the cover art on a CD for example, hmmm this is interesting, let me —

FA: Well that will cut both ways. So if you've got a cover — I just had a conversation with a young artist today and she — the package that she had — and she goes, "Would you like me to send this to you or would you like me to present it to you?" I go, "The way you phrased it I get the feeling you want to present this." She goes, "I am so excited about this." I go, "Then I want to get it from you." And she brought it over today and it was really, really well designed and cool. And I go, "This is great. The design is beautiful, what you've got here is really terrific. That looks great." That's something that if it came into the office I'd go oh wow, I wonder who this is, let me check it out. But then there's other things that — the cover is so bad that I'll either go, "What is this?" and put it to the side never to pick it up again. Or I go, "What is this? Let me put it on and see if it's good or bad or indifferent." But yeah.

RB: Are you looking for sidemen on it? Or like who's on it?

FA: Well the first thing is like the graphic. Is the graphic cool? Does it look like something that shows the artist as they are. Does it give an insight into the artist. That's number one. And then if there are sidemen on it, if I don't know the artist, sidemen certainly help. So that's awfully good. And then after that it's like it generally gets the one minute rule, which is put it on, listen a minute to the first song. All right that's good, let's see what's the second song. Okay, you get three songs in and you go okay let's go back to the beginning and let's listen to this now. They sound like they've got something going.

MR: You listen to a bit of the first three songs. Is that what you said?

FA: Yeah. To see if — and if it's just something that I go it's just not up my alley, you know, I'll give it to one of the other guys who I think it is up their alley. If it's something that I go, what the heck is this, you know, I'll ask the other guys if they've listened to this and we'll like each take a couple of shots, maybe listen to a couple of tracks and see if anybody likes it. That's what I like about, you know we've got three very different people with three very different sets of tastes on the magazine and we want it to be like that so we're casting that net wide. You had asked earlier about that, about do you make sure you've got Latin, do you make sure you've got this. Well we've got people with

like this." I may go, "Yeah that's not something I like but okay yeah, let's go." So does that answer your question?

RB: Yeah.

FA: Good.

RB: I think people watching will be watching this interview with that in mind.

MR: Good. Do you have a policy to send a letter back to people? Thanks for sending —

FA: No. Can't do it.

MR: Can't do it.

FA: But if they email, that's one of those things, if they email I may say hey listen, it's going to take four to six weeks for you to get an answer, and we will email them back and say yeah this is going to make it. We found a home for it in the issue, this issue, we're not going to be able to find a home for that. But the sad truth is most people are not marketing their stuff hard enough to get it to us, to get it to the top of the pile, to get us to listen, to develop a relationship with the editors of the magazine in some way, shape or form. There are people at this conference that we've never reviewed their stuff. But they come by the booth, they go, "I'm going to get there one day." And those are the people you really, really appreciate because they get the idea that there's a lot of competition out there in recorded music just as there's a lot of competition in jazz, and that's going to make a difference, that building that relationship with people at the company. Because if it comes down to, "Hey, Frank, we're thinking about doing this or this." I go, "I've met him, great guy, good person, a good solid artist, saw him play at the JEN conference, saw him play at wherever. We should give that a shot."

MR: All right. Well a fascinating conversation. And I wish your magazine a healthy future. And thanks for your time today.

FA: Thank you guys. This has been an honor.